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What's next with 5G in India: AI, drones, phones

Qualcomm's **Uday Dodla** gives us a behind-the-scenes insight

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With almost a year since 5G officially started rolling out in India, we spoke with Qualcomm India to get more insights into how 5G is going ahead – both on the handsets as well as telco side, even as 4G only devices approach their sunset.

"I think like any other G transition, if you look back at what happened when 4G was introduced, the 5G transition

is going exactly according to plan. After initial test beds came up in a few cities, handsets started coming in and then after the 5G networks got turned on, you have that critical mass multiplying very rapidly which is what's happening in the India context as well," said Uday Dodla, Senior Director, Business Development, Qualcomm India.

In fact, with the sales share of 5G smartphones in India having crossed the 50% mark for the first time in April 2023, with brands like Samsung and OnePlus capturing a third of the share, according to data by Counterpoint Research, the mix of handsets having 5G vs 4G has rapidly increased to 5G, according to Uday Dodla as well. "We are now hearing that this holiday season is when OEMs are expected to clear their inventory of 4G mobile phones, after which we'll

probably not see much 4G-only mobiles being sold anymore," he said.

That's the 5G story till date, according to Qualcomm India. And that's mostly a handset story. "We feel the 5G narrative outside of handsets is just beginning in India, especially related to last mile broadband connectivity. You know, with fixed wireless access, we are already seeing operators outside India adopting it very aggressively, specifically in the US for home broadband connectivity. We're going to see something very similar happen in India as well," Dodla emphasised.

That's right, apart from handsets 5G will initially be a broadband story. In terms of last mile broadband connectivity, where it's probably impossible or difficult to get fibre connection to your home, you place a wireless box, power it on and bingo, right? You suddenly have a signal, and it sure beats any kind of deployments that fibre would need – like all sorts of digging everywhere.

Qualcomm India's Dodla calls it the next phase of 5G growth, where some of the other services that 5G has promised are starting to show up in terms of industrial automation 5G for non consumer devices such as drones, for example.

Drones and 5G

Qualcomm's Flight RB5 5G platform for drones, which it claims is the world's 1st 5G and AI drone platform with Wi-Fi 6 connectivity, is being used for a variety of scenarios, according to Uday Dodla. "It supports everything from a simple drone to connected drones, to smarter drones with onboard AI, let's say a drone with five cameras – like a surveillance drone that's hovering – streaming all of that video concurrently will be a challenge. We have a lot of inference already built-in on the drone itself, so only the most relevant change, let's say there's a speeding car that gets detected very quickly, so only that information is sent down. These are some use cases of drone companies, which are growing in India," mentioned Dodla.